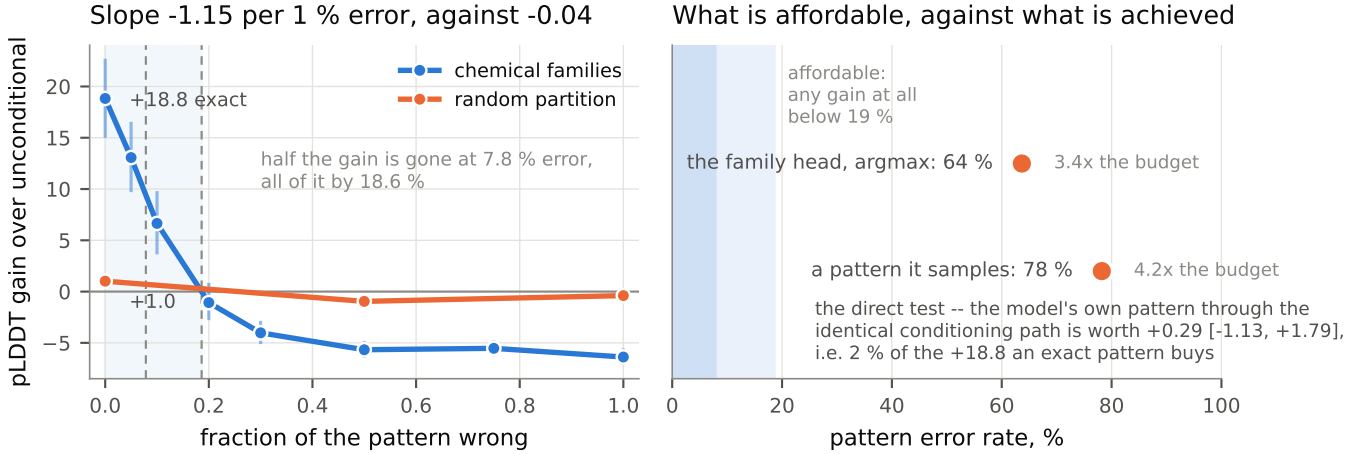A coarse chemical pattern is only useful while it is nearly exact